Forum:	Special Political and Decolonization Committee (GA4)
Issue:	The situation in Nakchivan
Author:	Petros Papadopoulos
Position:	Deputy President

Personal Introduction

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to this year's MoMUN. My name is Petros Papadopoulos, and I am honored to serve as a Deputy President of the Special Political and Decolonization Committee (GA4). It is a pleasure to welcome you to this committee, and I hope this conference will be both an enjoyable and rewarding experience for everyone.

I am currently a student at The Moraitis School, and I have been involved in Model United Nations for one year. Throughout my MUN journey, I have participated in conferences as a delegate and have had the opportunity to take on leadership roles as well. Every conference has taught me something new, whether about international politics, diplomacy, or simply the importance of listening to different perspectives and understanding global treaties.

One of the reasons I enjoy MUN is that it encourages us to think beyond our own opinions and represent the interests of another country as accurately as possible. It challenges us to research carefully, speak confidently, negotiate with others, and find solutions to complex international issues. At the same time, MUN is an opportunity to meet new people, exchange ideas, and learn from delegates with different experiences and viewpoints.

As a Deputy President in the GA4 of this year's conference, my goal is to create a committee where everyone feels comfortable participating. Whether this is your first conference or you have attended many before, I encourage you to contribute to the debate and make the most of the experience. Do not be afraid to speak up or share your ideas. MUN is a place to learn, improve, and grow, and every contribution helps make the discussion more meaningful.

I also encourage you to prepare thoroughly before the conference. Take the time to understand your country's foreign policy, research the topics on the agenda, and think about realistic solutions that can be supported through international cooperation.

I hope this study guide provides a useful starting point for your research and helps you better understand the issues we will be discussing. While it cannot cover every aspect of the topics, it is designed to give you the background information needed to begin your preparation. I encourage you to build on this information with your own research and come to a committee ready to engage in

thoughtful and respectful debate. Should you have any questions about this study guide, the procedures, or the conference, do not hesitate to contact me via email: ppamun2025@gmail.com

I wish you the best of luck with your preparation and am looking forward to meeting you.

Kind regards,

Petros

Introduction

The topic that will be discussed in this study guide concerns the 2026 amendments to the Constitution of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic, which redefine how Nakhchivan is governed and clarify its relationship with Azerbaijan. The amendments explicitly state that Nakhchivan is an inseparable part of the Republic of Azerbaijan and align its constitutional system more closely with Azerbaijan's 1995 Constitution. They also change the structure and powers of institutions in Nakhchivan, including replacing the former role of the Chairman of the Supreme Assembly with a system centered more strongly on the Representative of the President of Azerbaijan. This is important in the Nakhchivan matter because Nakhchivan has a special autonomous status within Azerbaijan, so changes to its Constitution directly affect who exercises political power, how the autonomous government functions, and how Nakhchivan fits into Azerbaijan's overall state structure. The 2026 constitutional amendments introduced significant institutional changes and strengthened the role of Azerbaijan's central executive authority in Nakhchivan.

Nakhchivan has held autonomous status within Azerbaijan in different forms since 1924. On 17 November 1990, during the late Soviet period, it adopted the name Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic, which it continues to use today. This distinction is important because 1990 marked a change in its constitutional designation rather than the creation of its autonomy. It possesses its own regional administrative and political institutions. Geographically, Nakhchivan is a landlocked exclave, meaning that it is separated from the main territory of Azerbaijan by another country, Armenia. It is bordered by Armenia to the north and east, Iran to the southwest, and Türkiye to the northwest, with which it shares a very short border. This unique geographical position places Nakhchivan at the intersection of several important regional states and gives the territory considerable geopolitical significance.

According to the 2019 population census, conducted from 1 to 10 October, Nakhchivan had a population of approximately 458,910 people. Azerbaijanis constituted approximately 99.7% of the population, while the remaining 0.3% consisted of other ethnic groups, including Kurds. Nakhchivan City is the capital and largest city of the autonomous republic and serves as its main political, administrative, economic, and cultural centre. The region has a long and complex history and has been influenced by various powers throughout the development of the South Caucasus. During the

Soviet period, Nakhchivan was part of the Azerbaijani Soviet Socialist Republic while maintaining a distinct autonomous status.

Following the dissolution of the Soviet Union, Nakhchivan remained an autonomous republic within the newly independent Republic of Azerbaijan. Its autonomous status distinguishes it from Azerbaijan's ordinary administrative regions and has historically given its regional institutions a particular role in local governance. Nakhchivan's geographical position also makes it important for regional transportation, trade, and connectivity. In particular, its border with Turkey provides Azerbaijan with a strategic connection to Turkey, while its borders with Iran and Armenia contribute to its wider regional importance. Therefore, Nakhchivan is significant not only within Azerbaijan but also in the broader political, economic, and security environment of the South Caucasus. Understanding its geography, population, history, and autonomous status is essential for understanding the wider Nakhchivan Matter.

The Nakhchivan matter has international importance because its location and political status affect the wider security and diplomatic environment of the South Caucasus. It is internationally recognised as part of Azerbaijan, but it is separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenia and borders Turkey and Iran. As a result, changes in Nakhchivan's governance can influence relations among several countries, even though the issue is primarily connected to Azerbaijan's internal constitutional system.

The 2026 constitutional amendments increased international attention by changing the distribution of political authority in Nakhchivan and strengthening the role of Azerbaijan's central government. These amendments raise questions about how domestic constitutional reforms relate to historical international agreements, particularly the Treaties of Moscow and Kars (1921). The issue is particularly relevant to Turkey because of its border, political partnership, and strategic relationship with Azerbaijan. It is also relevant to Iran, which borders Nakhchivan and has economic and security interests in the region. In addition, Nakhchivan's position within the broader Armenia-Azerbaijan relationship means that changes affecting the region could influence regional stability, transportation routes, trade, and cross-border cooperation.

The Nakhchivan Matter therefore concerns more than the internal organisation of one autonomous region. It involves sovereignty, territorial integrity, local self-government, international agreements, regional security, and the rights of local communities. The international community must consider how to respect Azerbaijan's authority while encouraging peaceful dialogue, legal clarity, regional cooperation, and meaningful representation for the people of Nakhchivan.

The Nakhchivan Matter is being debated because the 2026 constitutional amendments introduced significant changes to the governance of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic, particularly by strengthening the role of Azerbaijan's central government. This has created an important discussion surrounding the balance between Azerbaijan's sovereignty and territorial integrity and Nakhchivan's autonomous governance and political representation. The matter is important today because Nakhchivan's unique geographical position, bordering Armenia, Turkey, and Iran, gives

developments in the region wider implications for regional stability, trade, transportation, and diplomatic relations. These governance changes could potentially affect the distribution of resources, the administration of public services, and the balance of responsibilities between Nakhchivan's autonomous institutions and Azerbaijan's central authorities. This connects directly to the conference theme **"Equity in an Uneducated World"** which is relevant to the Nakhchivan Matter because political and institutional arrangements can influence how effectively people access essential public services, including education. Nakhchivan's geographical separation from mainland Azerbaijan can create particular challenges for connectivity and the delivery of services, making equitable access an important consideration. Changes in the balance between autonomous institutions and central authorities may also affect how responsibilities, funding, and public services are administered, although such effects should be considered as potential consequences rather than established outcomes. In this context, the committee should consider how governance and regional connectivity can support equal access to education and other opportunities, particularly for communities affected by geographical isolation. The debate therefore focuses not only on constitutional changes, but also on how governance, representation, education, and equitable development can coexist while respecting Azerbaijan's sovereignty.

Key Terms and Definitions

Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic

The Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic is an autonomous republic that forms part of the Republic of Azerbaijan. It is geographically separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenia and shares borders with Armenia, Iran, and Türkiye. Its autonomous status provides it with regional governmental institutions while sovereignty remains with Azerbaijan. Nakhchivan's geographical position makes it particularly significant to questions of regional security, transportation, and international relations.

Autonomy[1]

Autonomy refers to the authority granted to a territorial region to manage certain internal affairs through its own institutions while remaining constitutionally part of a sovereign state. It could also involve legislative, executive and/or administrative powers, depending on the constitutional arrangement.

Sovereignty

Sovereignty is the authority of a state to govern its territory and population and to exercise independent political and legal decision-making. However, sovereignty is exercised within the framework of international law and the obligations that states have accepted through treaties and other international agreements.

[1] "Autonomy", Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Autonomy, Accessed 7 October 2026

Territorial Integrity

Territorial integrity refers to the principle that a state's territory and internationally recognised boundaries should be respected and protected from unlawful alteration or forcible interference. While sovereignty concerns a state's authority to govern its territory and population, territorial integrity focuses on preserving the territory itself and its political unity. Article 2(4) of the UN Charter requires states to refrain from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of another state.

Zangezur / Syunik Corridor

The Zangezur or Syunik corridor refers to proposed transportation links through Armenia's Syunik region that could connect mainland Azerbaijan with Nakhchivan. The term is used in political and diplomatic discussions, but there is no single agreed legal model for such a route. The parties have different positions concerning sovereignty, border controls, customs procedures, and security arrangements. Therefore, any future route would depend on an agreement defining its legal status and operating conditions.

Treaty of Kars

The Treaty of Kars was signed on 13 October 1921 by Türkiye and the Soviet republics of Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia, with the participation of Soviet Russia. Regarding Nakhchivan, Article V established an international treaty framework under which the region, within the boundaries specified in the treaty's Annex III, constituted an autonomous territory under the protection of Azerbaijan. The treaty therefore forms an important part of the historical and legal framework concerning Nakhchivan's territorial status.

Regional Connectivity

Regional connectivity refers to the transportation, trade, and communication links between neighbouring countries and regions.

Border Demarcation

Border demarcation is the process of physically marking an agreed boundary between two states on the ground. It is usually carried out through technical surveys and the placement of agreed boundary markers. Clear demarcation is therefore important for preventing incidents and establishing predictable conditions for transportation and regional cooperation.

Transit Corridor

A transit corridor is an established route that allows the movement of people, goods, or vehicles between different territories, often passing through one or more states. Transit corridors can have significant economic and strategic importance because they connect markets and reduce transportation barriers.

Ceasefire

A ceasefire is a formal or informal agreement between parties to suspend armed hostilities, either temporarily or as part of a broader peace process. Ceasefires are intended to reduce violence and create conditions for diplomatic negotiations.

Gross Domestic Product (GDP)

Gross domestic product (GDP)[2] is a monetary measure of the total market value of final goods and services produced during a specific period of time (usually a year) by a country

Background Information

Ancient and Classical Period

Nakhchivan has a long history as a settlement and regional centre in the South Caucasus. In antiquity, it came under the influence or control of several regional powers, including the Median, Achaemenid Persian, and Armenian kingdoms. Its location along important routes between the Caucasus, Anatolia, and Iran contributed to its economic and strategic importance.

Persian, Byzantine, and Arab Rule

In 428, the Armenian Arshakuni monarchy was abolished, and Nakhchivan was incorporated into Sassanid Persia. In 623, control of the region temporarily passed to the Byzantine Empire. From approximately 640 onward, Arab forces invaded Nakhchivan and established control over the region. Arab rule brought significant political and demographic changes, while Armenian nobles and local populations continued to resist outside control.

Medieval Period and Turkic Rule

In the early tenth century, Nakhchivan came under the control of Bagratuni King Smbat I and was subsequently transferred to the princes of Syunik. The region was later controlled by several dynasties, including the Sajids, Sallarids, Shaddadids, and Seljuks. Around 1055, the Seljuk Turks took control of Nakhchivan. During the twelfth century, Nakhchivan City became the capital of the Atabegs of Azerbaijan, also known as the Ildegizid state[3], which controlled large parts of the South Caucasus and Iranian Azerbaijan.

Mongol and Post-Mongol Period

The Mongols first entered the South Caucasus in 1220, when forces led by Jebe and Subutai pursued the Khwarazmian ruler Muhammad II. This initial expedition involved raids and military engagements across the region. A second, more sustained campaign began in 1235–1236, leading to Mongol conquest across much of the South Caucasus. These events formed part of a series of

[2] "Gross Domestic Product", Wikipedia https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gross_domestic_product, Accessed 16 October 2026

[3] Kenneth Allin Luther, "ATĀBAKĀN-E ĀḎARBĀYJĀN" https://www.iranicaonline.org/articles/atabakan-e-adarbayjan/ , published 15 December 1987

campaigns rather than a single invasion, and Nakhchivan was affected by the wider destruction and political changes associated with Mongol expansion.[4]

Russian Expansion

Following the final Russo-Persian War, the Treaty of Turkmenchay[5] was signed on 10 February 1828 (Julian calendar), corresponding to 22 February 1828 (Gregorian calendar). Under the treaty, the Nakhchivan Khanate was transferred from Persian to Russian control. This marked a major change in Nakhchivan's political history and incorporated the region into the Russian Empire.

World War I and the Collapse of the Russian Empire[6]

During the final years of World War I and the collapse of the Russian Empire, Nakhchivan became the centre of political instability and competing territorial claims involving Armenian and Azerbaijani political representatives and local communities. Following the February Revolution of 1917, the region came under the authority of the Special Transcaucasian Committee established by the Russian Provisional Government. In 1918, it briefly fell under the authority of the Transcaucasian Democratic Federative Republic, which dissolved in May of that year. The newly established Republic of Armenia and Azerbaijan Democratic Republic subsequently advanced competing claims over Nakhchivan. Ottoman forces entered the region in 1918, and following the Armistice of Mudros on 30 October 1918, Ottoman troops were required to withdraw from the South Caucasus. British forces subsequently became involved in the region as Allied powers sought to manage the political and territorial disputes that followed the collapse of imperial rule. These developments contributed to continued instability and conflict over Nakhchivan's political status between 1918 and 1920.

Republic of Aras[7]

In December 1918, with the support of Azerbaijan's Musavat Party, Jafargulu Khan Nakhchivanski declared the Republic of Aras in Nakhchivan. The republic was not internationally recognised and faced opposition from the Armenian government. In June 1919, Armenian forces attempted to regain control of the territory, although Armenian administration was later expelled from Nakhchivan by the end of July 1919.

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[4] Clifford Edmund Bosworth, "Nak̲javān," Encyclopaedia Iranica https://www.iranicaonline.org/articles/nakjavan/ published 8 February 2013

[5] " The Treaty of Turkmenchay" Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Treaty_of_Turkmenchay, Accessed September 17 2026

[6] "Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic-Historical Overview" Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nakhchivan_Autonomous_Republic , Accessed 18 October 2026

[7] "Nakhchivan, the Armenian arguments and the Allied Powers in 1919","Kamala Imranli-Lowe", "Taylor and Francis Online", https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/00263206.2015.1122595 , published 3 March 2016

Treaties of Moscow[8] and Kars

The Treaty of Moscow, signed on 16 March 1921 between Soviet Russia and Türkiye, addressed Nakhchivan's status in Article III, providing for the region to constitute an autonomous territory under Azerbaijan's protection within specified boundaries. The Treaty of Kars, signed on 13 October 1921 between Türkiye and the Soviet republics of Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia, was a separate but related agreement negotiated with Soviet Russia's participation. Article V of the Treaty of Kars reaffirmed Nakhchivan's status as an autonomous territory under Azerbaijan's protection and referred to the territorial boundaries set out in Annex III. The two treaties therefore formed part of the international treaty framework concerning Nakhchivan's territorial status and autonomy. The Treaty of Kars was not the sole origin of this arrangement; rather, it reaffirmed and further specified provisions already addressed in the Treaty of Moscow.

Establishment of the Nakhchivan ASSR

On 9 February 1924, the Soviet authorities formally established the Nakhchivan Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic (ASSR) within the Azerbaijan SSR. Its constitution was adopted on 18 April 1926. During the Soviet period, Nakhchivan remained an autonomous territory within Soviet Azerbaijan while possessing its own regional institutions.

Soviet Era and Demographic Changes

During the Soviet period, Nakhchivan experienced major demographic changes. According to Soviet census data, the Armenian population represented approximately 11% of the population in 1926, while its proportion had declined to approximately 1.4% by 1979. By the end of the Soviet period, Nakhchivan had become overwhelmingly Azerbaijani in demographic composition.

These demographic changes later became significant in political and historical debates concerning the identity and territorial status of Nakhchivan.

Collapse of the Soviet Union and Restoration of Autonomy[9]

On 19 January 1990, amid rising political tensions and security concerns in the South Caucasus, the Supreme Council of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic adopted a declaration announcing the region's secession from the Soviet Union. The decision was an important expression of opposition to the Soviet authorities' handling of the crisis, but it should not be interpreted as meaning that Nakhchivan's legal separation from the USSR was conclusively completed at that time. Soviet officials questioned the declaration's legality, and the Soviet Union continued to exist until its dissolution in December 1991. On 17 November 1990, Nakhchivan adopted the name Nakhchivan

[8] "Treaty of Moscow", "Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic", https://nakhchivan.preslib.az/en_b3.html

[9] "How Nakhchivan Seceded from the USSR", https://alimajlis.gov.az/storage/custom/uploads/7Xn47WL14gJGw8kT9ty78SJ4Jl86OAJ1T5PwODD3.pdf , published 19 January, 2024

Autonomous Republic, marking a further change in its political designation during the final years of the Soviet period.

Post-Soviet Constitutional Development

After Azerbaijan became independent, Nakhchivan retained its autonomous status and developed its own regional governmental institutions, including the Supreme Assembly (Ali Majlis), Cabinet of Ministers, and judicial institutions. A new Constitution of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic was adopted on 29 December 1998. The constitutional framework established Nakhchivan as an autonomous republic within Azerbaijan while providing it with regional institutions and powers over matters falling within its competence. The geographical position of Nakhchivan also became increasingly important after the dissolution of the Soviet Union. Because the region is separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenia, its transportation, economic development, and access to external markets became major long-term challenges.

Post-2020 Regional Developments

The 9 November 2020 trilateral statement, signed by the leaders of Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Russia and effective from 10 November, called for the reopening of regional economic and transport links. Paragraph 9 specifically addressed transport connections between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenia, including the movement of people, vehicles, and goods. In the following years, negotiations focused on how these routes would operate, including questions of sovereignty, customs procedures, border controls, and security. Azerbaijan commonly refers to the proposed route through Armenia's Syunik region as the Zangezur Corridor, while Armenia maintains that transport through its territory must respect its sovereignty and jurisdiction. The 2020 statement did not establish a fully agreed legal and operational framework for a corridor.

On 8 August 2025, Armenia and Azerbaijan signed a joint declaration in Washington supporting connectivity between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenian territory, while affirming respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity, and jurisdiction. The declaration also proposed developing the Trump Route for International Peace and Prosperity (TRIPP) project. This marked a later stage in negotiations, distinct from the commitments made in 2020, and placed Nakhchivan's connectivity within broader efforts to improve regional trade, transportation, and cooperation in the South Caucasus.

2026 Constitutional Amendments[10]

On 2 February 2026, Azerbaijan adopted Constitutional Law No. 340-VIIKQD, amending the Constitution of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic. The amendments removed the references to the Treaties of Moscow and Kars from Article 1 and revised the preamble to state that Nakhchivan is an integral part of Azerbaijan, with its constitutional framework based on Azerbaijan's independence

[10] "Constitutional Law on Approval of Amendments to the Constitution of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic ", https://president.az/az/articles/view/71841/print , "President of Azerbaijan", published 2 February 2026

documents and 1995 Constitution. They also introduced an article establishing the President of Azerbaijan's authorized representative in Nakhchivan and changed the appointment of elections, the powers to dissolve the Ali Majlis, and the relationship between Nakhchivan's executive institutions and Azerbaijan's central authorities. The amendments therefore significantly reorganized the region's institutional framework and strengthened presidential influence. However, they did not formally abolish Nakhchivan's autonomous-republic status.

Geographic Isolation & Transit Connectivity

Nakhchivan is geographically separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenia, making transportation and communication with the rest of Azerbaijan more difficult. This isolation has increased the importance of transit routes connecting Nakhchivan with Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Iran, and international markets. A major point of discussion is the proposed Zangezur/Syunik transit route, which would pass through Armenia's Syunik region and provide a direct land connection between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan. The Azerbaijani government advocates opening this route to improve regional connectivity, while the Armenian government maintains that any transport links through its territory must operate under Armenian sovereignty, jurisdiction, and border regulations. The disagreement therefore concerns not only transportation, but also sovereignty, security, and control over transit. The issue also affects neighbouring states: Türkiye has close strategic ties with Azerbaijan, while Iran has expressed concerns about changes to regional borders and the geopolitical balance. Consequently, any agreement or continued disagreement over the route could influence regional trade, diplomatic relations, and security cooperation.

Sovereignty vs. Access Control

The issue of transit connectivity creates a difficult balance between Azerbaijan's right to maintain access to Nakhchivan and Armenia's right to control its sovereign territory. Questions arise over who would control customs, border checkpoints, security procedures, and the movement of people and goods along a potential transit route. Azerbaijan seeks reliable and efficient access to Nakhchivan, while Armenia has concerns about maintaining control over its territory and ensuring that any transportation arrangement does not create a loss of sovereignty. Finding a system that allows efficient transit while respecting territorial integrity is therefore one of the central challenges. The central legal question is whether transit will operate under Armenia's ordinary customs and border jurisdiction or under a specially negotiated arrangement. The 8 August 2025 Washington Declaration[11] affirmed that regional communications should respect the sovereignty, territorial integrity, and jurisdiction of the states involved, while providing for unimpeded connectivity between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenia. The practical implementation of these principles requires agreement on inspections, customs procedures, security responsibilities, and the movement of people and goods.

[11] "WashingtonDeclaration", https://www.state.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/2025JointDeclaration.AzerbaijanArmenia.pdf ,Signed 8 August 2025

Border Demarcation & Military Tensions

The Armenia–Azerbaijan border has experienced periods of military tension, including armed clashes and disputes over territorial control. Addressing these issues requires distinguishing between border delimitation and demarcation, and measures to reduce military tensions. Delimitation involves defining the border in official agreements and maps, while demarcation involves marking the agreed boundary on the ground. The two countries have made progress in this process, including agreements on specific border sections and procedures for continuing the work. Military de-escalation is a separate but related challenge. Communication between security forces, mutually agreed security measures, and clear protocols for responding to incidents can help reduce the risk of escalation while border negotiations continue. These measures are also relevant to the Nakhchivan Matter because unresolved border and security concerns may complicate plans for regional transport routes. Progress on both border arrangements and de-escalation could therefore support safer conditions for connectivity and wider regional cooperation.

Stakes & Regional / Global Impact

Geopolitical & Security Stakes

Nakhchivan's location gives the issue significance beyond Azerbaijan and Armenia, as it lies at the intersection of several regional interests. Türkiye and Azerbaijan maintain a strategic partnership, formalized by the 2021 Shusha Declaration, and view improved transport links through Nakhchivan as an opportunity to strengthen trade and connectivity between their countries. Iran, which shares a border with Nakhchivan, has economic and security interests in maintaining access to regional routes and preserving the existing international borders. It has expressed concern about proposals that could alter the regional balance or restrict its connections with Armenia. Meanwhile, Armenia–Azerbaijan normalization is central to determining whether transport links can reopen under mutually accepted arrangements. The 8 August 2025 Washington Declaration supported unimpeded connectivity between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenia while affirming state sovereignty, territorial integrity, and jurisdiction. These relationships mean that decisions about Nakhchivan's transport links could affect regional trade, diplomatic cooperation, and security. Agreed transit arrangements could create economic opportunities and support normalization, while unresolved disagreements over sovereignty, border controls, or security could increase tensions among neighbouring states. The issue therefore involves not only Azerbaijan's access to Nakhchivan, but also the wider balance of interests among Türkiye, Iran, Armenia, and Azerbaijan.

Economic & Trade Stakes

Improved connectivity involving Nakhchivan could strengthen trade between Azerbaijan, Türkiye, Iran, and other regional markets. If transport routes are reopened and supported by adequate infrastructure, Nakhchivan could become more closely connected to the **Middle Corridor**, which links Asia and Europe through Central Asia, the Caspian Sea, the South Caucasus, and Türkiye. However, these benefits are not guaranteed. Nakhchivan's role would depend on infrastructure

investment, efficient customs procedures, reliable transport services, and political agreements between the countries involved. The World Bank similarly identifies improved infrastructure and border procedures as important to the corridor's development. Unresolved disputes, border delays, and security concerns could limit trade and increase transportation costs. Therefore, Nakhchivan's potential contribution to the Middle Corridor depends on both practical improvements and effective regional cooperation. Successful implementation could create opportunities for trade, investment, and employment, but these outcomes would depend on how the remaining obstacles are addressed.

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Event
22 February, 1828	Treaty of Turkmenchay. Nakhchivan was transferred from Persian to Russian control following the Russo-Persian War. The treaty was dated 10 February 1828 in the Julian calendar.
1917	The February Revolution led to the collapse of Russian imperial authority and political instability across the South Caucasus. On 9 March 1917, the Russian Provisional Government established the Special Transcaucasian Committee (OZAKOM) to administer the region. Nakhchivan came under this changing administrative framework, as competing political claims and uncertainty over the region's future status grew.
4 June – 19 July 1918	Ottoman forces entered Nakhchivan amid the collapse of Russian authority and competing territorial claims in the South Caucasus. Under the Treaty of Batum, signed on 4 June 1918, the region came under Ottoman control. Following the Armistice of Mudros on 30 October, Ottoman troops were required to withdraw.

March 16, 1921	Signed by Türkiye and the Soviet republics of Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia, with Soviet Russia participating in the negotiations. The treaty confirmed Nakhchivan's autonomous status under Azerbaijan's protection and specified its territorial boundaries, helping establish the framework for its status within Azerbaijan.
October 13, 1921	Treaty of Kars. Signed between Turkey and the Soviet republics of Armenia, Azerbaijan and Georgia,with Soviet Russia involved in the negotiations. For Nakhchivan the agreements established its autonomous status within Azerbaijan and defined the territory's boundaries, while also creating a connection between Turkey and Nakhchivan.
February 9, 1924	The Nakhchivan Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic (ASSR) was formally established within the Azerbaijan SSR. This gave Nakhchivan an autonomous status while keeping it politically connected to Soviet Azerbaijan.
November 17, 1990	Nakhchivan adopted its current name, the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic.
February 2, 2026[12]	Azerbaijan approved significant amendments concerning Nakhchivan's constitutional and institutional structure. The reforms changed several aspects of how Nakhchivan's government operates.

Major Actors Involved

Azerbaijan

Azerbaijan is the sovereign state of which Nakhchivan is an autonomous republic. Nakhchivan's strategic location gives Azerbaijan important connections with Türkiye and Iran while also creating

[12] "President of Azerbaijan — Constitutional Law No. 340-VIIKQD",https://president.az/az/articles/view/71841/print

challenges because it is separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenia. Azerbaijan has consistently supported maintaining Nakhchivan as part of its territory and has sought stronger transportation links between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan. Azerbaijan's position became particularly important after the 2020 Armenia-Azerbaijan war, when discussions about regional transportation routes increased. Azerbaijan supports the proposed transit route through Armenia's Syunik region, often referred to as the Zangezur Corridor, to improve connections with Nakhchivan. Azerbaijan is also a party to the Treaty of Kars (1921), which, together with the Treaty of Moscow (1921), established arrangements concerning Nakhchivan's autonomous status under Azerbaijan's protection and defined its territorial boundaries. In 2026, Azerbaijan adopted Constitutional Law No. 340-VIIKQD, amending Nakhchivan's Constitution and strengthening the role of the central government in the region's institutions, while retaining Nakhchivan's status as an autonomous republic.

Armenia

Armenia is one of the most important states involved in the Nakhchivan Matter because Nakhchivan shares a border with Armenia and is separated from mainland Azerbaijan by Armenian territory. This geographical position makes Armenia central to discussions about transportation, border security, and regional connectivity. Following the 2020 Armenia-Azerbaijan war, Armenia and Azerbaijan began discussing the possibility of opening transportation routes across the region. The Armenian government supports reopening regional transport links through its Crossroads of Peace initiative. It maintains that routes through Armenia must respect its sovereignty, jurisdiction, and border regulations. This differs from Azerbaijan's preferred framing of the proposed route as the "Zangezur Corridor." The disagreement between Armenia and Azerbaijan over the proposed Zangezur/Syunik transit route therefore involves both economic interests and questions of territorial sovereignty. Armenia as a Soviet republic party was also a signatory to the Treaty of Kars (1921) and has been directly involved in the wider Armenia-Azerbaijan conflict addressed by several UN Security Council resolutions.

Türkiye

Türkiye plays an important role because of its direct western border with Nakhchivan through a small land connection. This makes Türkiye one of Nakhchivan's most important external partners for transportation, trade, and economic development. Türkiye has strong political and strategic relations with Azerbaijan and has supported improving transportation connections between Türkiye, Azerbaijan, and Nakhchivan. A functioning route through the South Caucasus could strengthen Türkiye's connection with Azerbaijan and Central Asia and contribute to wider Eurasian trade routes. In 1921, the government of the Turkish Grand National Assembly signed the Treaty of Moscow with Soviet Russia. Later that year, Türkiye signed the Treaty of Kars with the Soviet republics of Armenia, Azerbaijan, and Georgia, with Soviet Russia participating in the negotiations. These agreements established important arrangements concerning Nakhchivan's autonomous status under Azerbaijan's protection and its territorial boundaries. The historical signatories should be distinguished from the modern states that later succeeded them.

United Nations

The United Nations (UN) has played an important role in addressing the wider Armenia-Azerbaijan conflict and the principles of territorial integrity and peaceful settlement that are relevant to Nakhchivan. Azerbaijan also directly brought the security situation in Nakhchivan to the attention of the Security Council in May 1993. In 2008, the UN General Assembly adopted Resolution 62/243, which reaffirmed respect for Azerbaijan's sovereignty and territorial integrity. These UN documents provide an important international framework for understanding the security and territorial issues surrounding Nakhchivan.

UN Documents and International Agreements

UN Security Council Resolution 822[13]

Date: 30 April 1993

Document: S/RES/822 (1993)

UN Security Council Resolution 822, adopted on 30 April 1993, called for an immediate ceasefire, the withdrawal of occupying forces from Kelbajar and other recently occupied Azerbaijani territories, renewed negotiations, and humanitarian access. It reaffirmed respect for states' sovereignty and territorial integrity. Its relevance to the Nakhchivan Matter is indirect, as it addressed the wider Armenia–Azerbaijan conflict rather than Nakhchivan specifically. The resolution's demands were not fully implemented at the time, and hostilities continued.

Letter from Azerbaijan Concerning Nakhchivan[14]

Date: 14 May 1993

Document: S/25785

In this official communication, Azerbaijan informed the UN Security Council about military operations affecting the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic. It brought the security situation of Nakhchivan directly to the attention of the international community. This document is important because it shows that Nakhchivan was directly affected by the wider Armenia-Azerbaijan conflict. It was an official diplomatic communication rather than a binding UN resolution.

UN Security Council Resolution 853[15]

Date: 29 July 1993

[13] "Resolution 822 (1993)","United Nations Official Document System"Resolution 822 (1993) /

[14] "Letter Dated 14 May 1993 from the Permanent Representative of Azerbaijan to the United Nations Addressed to the President of the Security Council." United Nations Digital Library, 17 May 1993, digitallibrary.un.org/record/167053

[15]United Nations. "Document on the Situation in Nakhchivan, Submitted to the United Nations" United Nations Official Document System, documents.un.org/doc/undoc/gen/n93/428/16/pdf/n9342816.pdf .

Document: S/RES/853 (1993)

UN Security Council Resolution 853, adopted on 29 July 1993, condemned the seizure of Agdam and other recently occupied Azerbaijani territories. It called for the withdrawal of occupying forces, a lasting ceasefire, negotiations, and humanitarian assistance. The resolution reaffirmed Azerbaijan's territorial integrity and the inviolability of international borders. Its relevance to the Nakhchivan Matter is indirect: it addressed the wider Armenia–Azerbaijan conflict, not Nakhchivan's constitutional status.

UN Security Council Resolution 874[16]

Date: 14 October 1993

Document: S/RES/874 (1993)

UN Security Council Resolution 874, adopted on 14 October 1993, called for a lasting ceasefire and supported negotiations through the CSCE Minsk Group. Paragraph 5 specifically called for the removal of all obstacles to communications and transportation. This is relevant to Nakhchivan because its geographic separation from mainland Azerbaijan makes regional connectivity important. However, the resolution addressed the wider Armenia–Azerbaijan conflict, not Nakhchivan specifically.

UN Security Council Resolution 884[17]

Date: 12 November 1993

Document: S/RES/884 (1993)

UN Security Council Resolution 884, adopted on 12 November 1993, condemned ceasefire violations and called for an immediate end to hostilities, the withdrawal of occupying forces from Zangilan, Goradiz, and other recently occupied Azerbaijani territories, and renewed peace negotiations. It also reaffirmed Azerbaijan's territorial integrity and the inviolability of international borders. Its relevance to Nakhchivan is indirect, as it addressed the wider Armenia–Azerbaijan conflict rather than Nakhchivan's status specifically.

UN General Assembly Resolution 62/243[18]

Date: 14 March 2008

Document: A/RES/62/243

[16]United Nations Security Council. "Resolution 874 (1993)." United Nations, 14 Oct. 1993, documents.un.org/doc/undoc/gen/n93/557/41/pdf/n9355741.pdf

[17] United Nations Security Council. "Resolution 884 (1993)." United Nations, 12 Nov. 1993, documents.un.org/doc/undoc/gen/n93/631/20/pdf/n9363120.pdf

[18]United Nations General Assembly. "Resolution 62/243: The Situation in the Occupied Territories of Azerbaijan." United Nations, 14 Mar. 2008, docs.un.org/en/a/res/62/243

UN General Assembly Resolution 62/243, adopted on 14 March 2008, reaffirmed respect for Azerbaijan's sovereignty and territorial integrity within its internationally recognised borders and addressed the situation in the occupied territories of Azerbaijan. It also called for the withdrawal of Armenian forces from those territories and supported a peaceful settlement of the conflict. Its relevance to the Nakhchivan Matter is indirect: although it reinforces the principle of territorial integrity, it does not determine Nakhchivan's specific constitutional status or the terms of its transport links with mainland Azerbaijan.

Previous Attempts to Solve the issue

Establishment of Nakhchivan's Autonomous Status

The first major attempt to address Nakhchivan's political and territorial position came through the 1921 Treaties of Moscow and Kars, which established the framework for Nakhchivan's status and confirmed its connection to Azerbaijan. Nakhchivan subsequently developed as an autonomous territory, and its autonomous status was formally maintained after Azerbaijan became independent. These arrangements created the historical and legal foundation for Nakhchivan's special position within Azerbaijan.

17 November 1990 — Reaffirmation of Nakhchivan's Autonomous Status

Nakhchivan removed "Soviet Socialist" from its official name, adopting the name Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic. The changes also renamed its legislative body the Supreme Majlis and adopted the tricolour flag of the Azerbaijan Democratic Republic as Nakhchivan's state flag. These decisions reaffirmed its distinct regional identity during the final years of the Soviet Union without creating its autonomous status anew.

The 1995–1998 Constitutional Framework

Following Azerbaijan's independence, a new constitutional framework was developed for Nakhchivan. The Constitution of Azerbaijan adopted in 1995 established Nakhchivan as an autonomous republic within Azerbaijan, while the Nakhchivan Constitution was subsequently adopted and approved within the Azerbaijani constitutional system. It provided for a separation of powers between the Ali Majlis, Cabinet of Ministers, and courts. Azerbaijan's 1995 Constitution and Nakhchivan's 1998 Constitution defined the region's autonomous status. The Ali Majlis handles regional legislation, including taxation, economic development, and culture, the Cabinet of Ministers manages executive affairs, and regional courts exercise judicial power. All operate within Azerbaijan's constitutional and legal framework.

Possible Solutions

Create a Formal Consultation System

Azerbaijan could establish a permanent consultation mechanism between its central government and Nakhchivan's regional authorities. Representatives could meet regularly to discuss major decisions concerning education, infrastructure, healthcare, and economic development, allowing regional concerns to be considered before national policies are implemented. The mechanism could also help identify local needs, coordinate funding, and resolve disagreements between central and regional authorities. This would be a domestic Azerbaijani institutional proposal, not a system the UN could impose. It would operate within Azerbaijan's constitutional framework, preserving the country's sovereignty while ensuring that Nakhchivan's specific needs receive greater consideration in national decision-making.

Guarantee Local Representation

Nakhchivan's representation could be strengthened through its existing institutions, particularly the Ali Majlis and the Cabinet of Ministers. Elected members of the Ali Majlis could represent residents' concerns, propose regional policies, and oversee decisions on matters such as education, healthcare, and economic development. The Cabinet could communicate local priorities to Azerbaijan's central government and coordinate their implementation. This proposal would preserve central authority over national matters, such as foreign policy and national security, while ensuring that Nakhchivan's residents have meaningful representation in decisions affecting their daily lives. It would build on existing institutions rather than require an entirely new governance system.

Establish a Dedicated Education Development Programme

Azerbaijan could introduce a long-term education programme specifically for Nakhchivan, focusing on renovating schools, improving internet access, and providing digital learning resources for students in remote areas. The programme could also offer incentives such as housing support and professional development to attract and retain qualified teachers. Partnerships with universities across Azerbaijan could expand access to online courses, scholarships, and student exchange opportunities. This proposal would address educational disadvantages linked to Nakhchivan's geographical isolation by improving access to quality education and higher learning. It would support the conference theme, "Equity in an Uneducated World," by promoting more equal educational opportunities regardless of location. Implementation could be led by Azerbaijan's Ministry of Science and Education in cooperation with Nakhchivan's regional authorities, building on the country's existing education development strategy.

Introduce Transparent Regional Funding

Azerbaijan could establish a clear funding framework specifying how national funds are allocated to Nakhchivan for education, healthcare, infrastructure, and economic development. Annual public reports could detail the amounts allocated and spent, projects completed, and progress towards development targets. Independent audits could verify the accuracy of these reports and identify cases

of inefficient spending. This system would improve accountability and allow residents to assess whether public funds are meeting regional needs. It would build on existing budget reporting practices while making funding for Nakhchivan more transparent and measurable.

Improve Transportation and Connectivity

Azerbaijan could continue improving roads, railways, telecommunications, and trade infrastructure connecting Nakhchivan with mainland Azerbaijan and neighbouring countries. These improvements could reduce geographical isolation and expand access to education, employment, and economic opportunities. Any international transport route passing through Armenia must respect Armenian sovereignty and agreed border and customs procedures. Cooperation between the countries could help establish reliable transit arrangements that benefit both sides while respecting their territorial integrity. This approach aligns with the 8 August 2025 Washington Declaration, which supports unimpeded connectivity while affirming state sovereignty, territorial integrity, and jurisdiction.

Conduct a Regular Review of the Amendments

Azerbaijan could introduce a periodic review of the 2026 constitutional amendments to assess their practical effects on administration, local representation, and equal access to public services and education. The review could involve relevant national ministries, Nakhchivan's Ali Majlis, and regional authorities, using public reports, service data, and feedback from residents to identify problems. The findings could be published in a report with recommendations and a timetable for addressing any shortcomings. If changes are needed, they could be introduced through Azerbaijan's existing constitutional and legal procedures, rather than automatically reversing the reforms. This would allow the governance system to adapt over time, improve accountability, and address regional inequalities while maintaining Azerbaijan's sovereignty.

Regional Transport Dialogue and Confidence-Building

Armenia and Azerbaijan could establish regular negotiations involving transport, customs, and border officials to agree on practical arrangements for reopening and operating regional routes. Discussions could address customs inspections, transit documentation, infrastructure security, and procedures for resolving disruptions. A joint working group could monitor implementation, exchange information, and help resolve technical disagreements before they escalate. This proposal builds on the 8 August 2025 Washington Declaration, which supports connectivity between mainland Azerbaijan and Nakhchivan through Armenia while affirming the sovereignty, territorial integrity, and jurisdiction of both states. International partners could provide technical assistance or facilitate dialogue if both countries agree, but any arrangements would require the states' consent and respect for their legal authority. Together, these proposals combine domestic governance improvements with regional cooperation. Their implementation would depend on political commitment, adequate resources, and coordination between the relevant authorities.

Further reading

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2. "Constitution of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic",*Ali Majlis of the Nakhchivan Autonomous Republic*, www.alimajlis.gov.az/en/pages/n-ar-constitution.
3. "Joint Declaration by the President of the Republic of Azerbaijan and the Prime Minister of the Republic of Armenia on the Outcomes of Their Meeting in Washington, D.C.",*The Prime Minister of the Republic of Armenia*, 8 Aug. 2025, www.primeminister.am/en/press-release/item/2025/08/09/Nikol-Pashinyan-visit-US-declaration/.

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